Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 28, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S13 -- 2001 Model Year Ford Focus, Seat Back Recliner Handle Spring

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a safety recall involving 2001 Model Year Ford Focus sedans and wagons from March 12, 2001 through March 22, 2001.
- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 11,500 vehicles (approximately 8,500 in the United States, 1,800 in Canada, and 1,200 in Mexico).
- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- The seat back recliner handle spring may have been damaged during an in-process test and the occupant may notice a chucking, or perceived looseness of the front seat back, or the seat back may unexpectedly recline. If the seat back unexpectedly reclines while the car is being driven, it could result in loss of vehicle control.
- Service Procedure -- Dealers will replace the seat back recliner handle spring for the driver and front passenger seat of all vehicles built during this time period.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S07 5d/sls/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S13 -- 2001 MODEL YEAR FOCUS SEAT BACK RECLINER HANDLE SPRING

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 2001 Model Year Ford Focus sedans and wagons built at the Wayne Assembly Plant from March 12, 2001 through March 22, 2001 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

The recliner mechanisms mentioned later in this letter were supplied to Ford by Visteon as part of the seat assembly. The recliner mechanisms were manufactured by Johnson Controls, Inc. (referred to as JCI), Automotive Systems Division, 49200 Halyard Drive, Plymouth, MI 48170. JCI's phone number is (734) 254-5801.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 8,500 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

A secondary check of the seat recliner mechanism conducted by a supplier could have damaged the recliner handle spring. Damage to the spring could result in the loss of handle tension that could result in an insufficient force to engage or retain the locking pawl of the recliner during normal use. Both the driver and front occupant seat backs could unexpectedly recline from the adjusted seat position. If the seat back unexpectedly reclines while the car is being driven, it could result in loss of vehicle control.

Ford is unaware of any reports of accidents or injuries as a result of the condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

On March 16, 2001, the 3rd shift operators at Wayne Assembly identified a concern with the front seatbacks during vehicle assembly. On March 17, 2001, JCI developed and implemented use of a spring wrench for the secondary check to prevent over-rotation/damage caused by the manual check. On March 19, 2001, JCI personnel confirmed that some of the seat recliner handle springs had been damaged and the spring tension could be insufficient to hold the adjusted seat position. Visteon replaced recliner springs in seats manufactured before March 17, 2001 and provided Ford a clean date of March 19, 2001. On March 20, 2001, JCI returned to the original process utilized since Job #1 and no longer performed the secondary check. On March 22, 2001, the suspect condition was again found at Wayne Assembly. JCI determined that the spring wrench was also able to damage the recliner spring and the previous clean point was now compromised. An additional stop ship was issued on March 22, 2001. Vehicles built after March 23, 2001 use seats which do not exhibit the suspect condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford notified dealers on March 22, 2001 not to demonstrate or deliver the affected vehicles, and will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for replacement of the seat back recliner handle spring in both front outboard seats. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of April 30, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press Statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. The advance notice to dealers was issued March 22, 2001 and a copy is enclosed. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S13 to this action.